

One Choice Changes Everything

CHOOSE YOUR WORK



Redefine Success and Discover the Work
That Makes You Feel Fully Alive

DAN DOBOS

2

The Unexpected Gifts Hidden in Your Struggles

How to extract insights from your greatest challenges so they become pathways for growth.

What Do the Leaning Tower of Pisa, Improvised Jazz, and Japanese Pottery Have in Common?

The Leaning Tower of Pisa was created by accident. A mistake made during its construction in 1173 caused the tower to tilt. In fact, the defective structural design had to be stabilized from a 5.5-degree tilt to a 3.97-degree tilt in the 1990s for safety reasons. Yet this unintentional defect has become one of its most celebrated features, drawing visitors from around the world. The defect created the beauty.

When musicians play improvised jazz, by definition, they do not follow the notes on the score. We delight in the new melodies formed by the deviation from the planned composition.

Imagine a shattered teacup, not discarded, but painstakingly pieced back together, the cracks filled with shimmering gold. This is *kintsugi*, a practice in Japanese pottery that sees beauty in imperfections. Instead of hiding the flaws, they are accentuated, creating a unique and beautiful piece of art.

CHOOSE YOUR WORK

The Leaning Tower of Pisa, improvised jazz, and the Japanese art of *kintsugi* highlight how there is beauty in the unexpected, the irregular, the interruption of the pattern. You are no different. Your specific challenges are a high-definition image of your authenticity. No one else has experienced your difficulties with the level of detail and clarity that you have. Your challenges contain seeds of brilliance that you can use to create distinctive work.

The challenging experiences that leave you feeling shattered are not meant to be hidden. Just as the *kintsugi* artisan carefully restores each crack, you too can pick up the fragments of your past and begin the process of golden repair.

Just as a jazz musician is valued for their unique melodies, you too will find success by tackling issues connected to your personal struggles. The first step is to recognize that you are not your work.



Figure 2: The practice of kintsugi accentuates flaws by filling them with gold.
View and download this photo in full color at:
ChooseYourWorkBook.com/kintsugi

You Are Not Your Work

The most common reaction that people have when they think back to emotionally challenging experiences is, “Oh, I just wasn’t good enough.”

That’s very different from writing an article and wondering, “Is this a high-quality article?” This is a great question to ask because it will help you identify the criteria for high-quality work. By knowing these criteria, you will write a better article.

Observe the difference between “Is this a high-quality article?” and “Am I a good writer?” When you ask the latter question, you might hesitate and lower your self-worth. This leads to a feeling of despair. Instead of facing challenges and giving them your best shot, you get swept up in a mixture of overthinking and insecurity.

So how do we separate the two? Challenge the quality of your work, but never challenge your self-worth. At your core, you are whole. Nothing can diminish your inherent value.

You can further improve the quality of your work by changing “Is this a high-quality article?” to “What could make this article better?” This more specific approach avoids the heightened emotion connected to the vague “This is great” versus “This is terrible.” Your most perceptive insights emerge when you sit behind the article and contemplate both its strengths and weaknesses. Notice how this has everything to do with the article and nothing to do with you.

In the same way that you separate the quality of your work from the quality of yourself, it is equally important to distinguish between what happened in the past and who you are today. You are not your work. You are not your profession. You are not the situations you have encountered. You are something far greater.

In light of this separation, let’s now examine what happens if you fail to confront your past challenges.

The Problem with Ignoring a Challenging Experience

When I was working in the corporate world, I was emotionally disconnected from my work. My initial discomfort wasn't a sharp pain that was strong enough to compel change. Instead, it was more like a dull, recurring ache, the kind that lingers in the background and slowly wears you down. A persistent gray fog, absent of both joy and sadness, settled over my daily lukewarm mediocrity.

Some people suffer their entire lives with this familiar discomfort to the point that they stop noticing it. I eventually realized that when I numbed myself to one feeling, I actually numbed myself to all feelings. By failing to engage with my emotions, I was trapped in a maze of indecision, constantly second-guessing my choices and desires.

When you ignore your feelings, you are more likely to get stuck in unsatisfying work. The only thing worse than doing unsatisfying work is pretending that it's not a problem.

When you notice pain, feel the pain. When you notice joy, feel the joy.

Think back to a time in your past that was both emotionally intense and difficult to navigate. Pause to recall the specific sensations that you remember experiencing. Only by fully feeling the moment can you comprehend its larger significance.

Here is a series of comparisons by psychologist Steven C. Hayes to help you feel an experience more fully. For each comparison, pause long enough to connect it to a challenging experience.

Hold your experience like a delicate flower in your hand.

Embrace your experience like a crying child.

Sit with your experience like you would sit with a person with a serious illness.

Look at your experience like you would look at an incredible painting.

Walk with your experience like you'd walk while carrying a sobbing infant.

THE UNEXPECTED GIFTS HIDDEN IN YOUR STRUGGLES

Honor your experience like you'd honor a friend by listening carefully even if it was hard.

Inhale your experience the way you would take a deep breath.

Abandon the fight like a soldier putting down the weapon and walking home.

Take in your experience like a glass of pure cold water.

Carry your experience like a picture in your wallet.

In business, I've faced several setbacks. These comparisons have been invaluable in helping me to peacefully reconnect with a challenging experience, reframe it, and gain clarity. They have helped me realize that compassion is not just important for the sake of being kind to others. We are all grappling with our own internal struggles. By recognizing that most people are doing the best they can with what they have, compassion helps you to see more clearly.

Now that you have felt your challenging experience more fully, the next step is to let it go.

The Rock Concert

We're now going to transform your challenging experience into something new by doing an activity together.

Take a moment to revisit the experience and concentrate on a specific feeling it evokes. It could be anxiety — the tension or unease from a perceived threat. Maybe it's sadness — a heaviness or sorrow weighing on your mind. You might feel anger — a sense of resentment or irritation toward a situation or a certain person. Perhaps it's guilt — the feeling of responsibility for something that went wrong. Or maybe it's disappointment — the letdown when expectations are not met. Whichever emotion you notice, allow yourself to feel it fully for ten seconds.

Imagine you're standing in front of the stage at a rock concert, close enough to touch the performers. You don't just hear the music; you feel it reverberating through every bone in your body. The pounding bass

CHOOSE YOUR WORK

echoes in your chest as the scent of smoke and sweat mingles in the air around you. Strobe lights flash intensely, painting the crowd in rapid, fleeting bursts of color.

This rock concert is a metaphor for your challenging experience — intense, overwhelming, and transformative. Don't engage with any words or thoughts. Just surrender to the raw sensation of the moment, letting it wash over you and carry you away on a tide of pure emotion.

Now imagine you're in a helicopter above the concert. With binoculars, you zoom in and see yourself immersed deeply in the rock concert, immersed in that painful experience. But when you take away the binoculars, you see everyone else at the concert. You can see the band, the lights, and thousands of people. You become a witness to the experience. Instead of being swept up by the emotion, you sit back in your seat and relax behind it, looking at the scene from a distance.

You stay with it. You don't comment. You simply observe it. You see it in its entirety, and then... you let it go. The helicopter departs from the scene. You look back toward the concert as it gets smaller and smaller and then disappears.

You are no longer there. The concert is now in the past. You are here in the present. It's a prior experience. It's not you. And as you let it go:

- Breathe in the difficulty for four seconds... and breathe out for six seconds and let it go...
- Breathe in the difficulty for four seconds... and breathe out for six seconds and let it go...
- Breathe in the difficulty for four seconds... and breathe out for six seconds and let it go...

And you notice that you now feel a little bit lighter.

Look at the fragments of your experience. Were they broken, chipped, shattered? Take a breath. Imagine you're a *kintsugi* master, picking up the

pieces of this experience. As you allow gold to flow through the cracks, what was once pain is now transformed into beauty.

The experience is still part of you, but it no longer defines you. It transforms into something beautiful and strong that will guide you in the next stage of your journey. The transformation not only enriches your life, but by letting go of the past, you are able to make space for the future. With a lighter load, you are much better positioned to discover the work that you are meant to do.

Who Am I Now?

Too often we criticize our prior actions — even those from several years ago — to the point that we let them distort our present experience. Yet the cells in our bodies are replaced daily. In about ninety days, most of your roughly 30 trillion cells will transform into new ones. You are not only a more mature and experienced person with evolved thinking patterns; you are also a biologically different person from who you were several years ago.

If you were exactly the same person you were many years ago, you might be angry with yourself because you may repeat the same behavior. But you are a different person now. Even if you wanted to, replicating the past would be almost impossible. Yes, breathe a huge sigh of relief because the past is over and done with. You will still face challenges, and even if elements of the past repeat, knowing the future will differ from the past should bring you some joy. As your capacity to respond grows, you will have new, richer, and more interesting experiences than ever before.

After even a mildly intense experience, it can be interesting to ponder: Who am I now? How have I evolved? The answer: it's a mystery. You never quite know exactly who you are. All that you can be sure of is that you have grown. Maturity is about accepting the flux of life and recognizing that failure is baked into the process of growth.

How Your Challenges Help You Grow

Rabbi Harold Kushner reflected on the death of his son, who tragically passed away from a rare genetic disease at just fourteen years old. He said:

I'm a more sensitive person, a more effective pastor, a more sympathetic counselor because of Aaron's life and death than I would've been without it. And I would give up all those gains in a second if I could have my son back. If I could choose, I would forego all of the spiritual growth and depth, which has come my way because of our experience. But I cannot choose.

He not only accepted what happened, but he learned from it, grew from it, and moved forward. That's what we want to do now. We must take this difficult experience and move beyond acceptance. We must use it as a springboard to grow.

Viktor Frankl, an Austrian psychiatrist, personifies such growth. While trapped in the atrocities of a concentration camp, he articulated a profound truth with exceptional clarity:

We who lived in concentration camps can remember the men who walked through the huts comforting others, giving away their last piece of bread. They may have been few in number, but they offer sufficient proof that everything can be taken from a person but one thing: the last of the human freedoms — to choose one's attitude in any given set of circumstances, to choose one's own way.

To help survive these atrocious conditions, Frankl wrote notes about his work and hid them in his coat. He was dedicated to his craft for his entire lifetime. He knew what he stood for. For Frankl, psychiatry wasn't merely a profession. It was a calling. He knew that he was sent to do this work. So he did it, and he did it exceptionally well. Indeed, after being freed from the concentration camp, Frankl wrote his groundbreaking book *Man's Search for Meaning* in just nine days.

Sixty-nine years after Viktor Frankl wrote his book, Anthony Ray Hinton was released from prison in another part of the world. After

being framed by the police, Hinton was wrongfully imprisoned for a full thirty years, spending almost his entire time on death row. His Alabama prison cell was infested with rats and cockroaches. He was given scarcely enough food to survive. He spent barely fifteen minutes a day out of his cell. He heard the shrieks of other cellmates being executed in the electric chair. Then the odor of death filled the air, leaving a grim reminder of the execution that occurred just meters away.

How would you respond to these living conditions? While most would lose their composure, Hinton responded with a level of character that we can only hope to emulate, an inimitable ability to transcend the horrific conditions he endured and the gross injustice so mercilessly inflicted upon him. Recounting his experiences, this great man echoed the wisdom of Viktor Frankl, stating:

Despair was a choice. Hatred was a choice. Anger was a choice. I still had choices and that knowledge rocked me... I could choose to give up or to hang on. Hope was a choice. Faith was a choice. And more than anything, love was a choice.

While falsely imprisoned, Hinton established a book club for fellow inmates. After his release, instead of retreating into a private life, Hinton did the opposite. He devoted himself to public speaking, offering hope to those confronted by injustice. His quiet strength and powerful message resonated globally as he harnessed the transformative power of suffering to uplift the lives of others. Hinton's lost years behind bars fueled his public speaking with an intense energy that deeply impacted the lives of those who heard him speak.

Kushner, Frankl, and Hinton each accomplished something very rare. They mastered the art of emotional judo. Judo is the art of using your opponent's weight to redirect their force instead of confronting it head-on. Similarly, emotional judo harnesses negative emotions so that, instead of letting them weaken you, their weight elevates you to a higher level of consciousness. These men transcended their situations by choosing hope over despair, offering us a profound example of how to live.

CHOOSE YOUR WORK

These experiences highlight that while there will always be challenges, the inescapable question is: Are you willing to use the force of these difficulties to create a transformation? These experiences are valuable because they give you depth, mold your character, and improve the quality of your thinking. As Camus put it, “In the depths of winter, I finally learned that within me there lay an invincible summer.”

These men also teach us how struggles can become the driving force behind work that is personally fulfilling and valuable to others. Just as Frankl further excelled in psychology and Hinton devoted himself to advocating for justice, you too can establish a new path illuminated by your challenging experiences.

Hopefully, you haven’t endured a fraction of the atrocities faced by Kushner, Frankl, or Hinton. However, if you hadn’t struggled at all, you wouldn’t appreciate the contrast between your past and present. More importantly, you can use these past struggles as seeds to cultivate something beautiful. The pain loses its sting when you absorb its lesson.

This is just the first stage of your journey. Your past challenges are here to help you navigate the next stage.

As the Zen proverb states, *Who knows what is good or bad luck?* It is easy to fall into the trap of believing that getting what you want will create the best experience for you. But more often, it is in the thick of challenging experiences that you uncover hidden gems. It is in these experiences that you break barriers, change perceptions, and create memories that leave an indelible mark on your life.

How to Channel Your Emotions to Build Something Remarkable

When John Wilson was twelve years old, his chemistry class participated in a routine experiment involving boiling water. Unfortunately, a lab assistant had mislabeled a bottle, so instead of boiling water, John boiled a much more reactive substance. The substance caused the container to

explode, shattering many glass bottles. Tragically, John Wilson left that science experiment completely blind.

Most people would be devastated, sink into depression, and lose hope. But John just got on with it. He quickly learned to read Braille, became an accomplished rower, swimmer, and actor, and studied law at Oxford University.

At age twenty-seven, he found himself in Africa. He noticed that blindness was far more prevalent there than in the Western world due to a lack of medical resources. He reflected on how his blindness resulted from an accident and grew angry that millions of others were blind simply due to insufficient resources. Something had to be done, so John established several organizations that helped prevent blindness in tens of millions of people.

If Sir John Wilson could turn his deeply unfortunate experience into a project that helped millions of people, what might be buried in your challenging experience, waiting to be uncovered? Observe the mixture of anger, frustration, and compassion that John felt and how he channeled that energy into something useful. Now, tap into the emotions that your challenges elicit. Feel the emotion deeply. Just as the *kintsugi* artist fills the cracks with gold, use the energy that comes from your challenges to create something that matters to you. Choose the work that fills the cracks with gold.

The Value of Writing About Challenges

When you write about your challenges, you release ideas that were taxing your mind. You expel negative emotions from your body. What once burdened your mind and strained your body now exists in its own place, on its own sheet of paper, separate from you. Now that you are no longer gripped by this narrow emotional focus, you can broaden your gaze and consider related thoughts. This is how you develop perspective.

The more you write, the more your writing reveals to you that you are not your thoughts. You are not your experiences. Your thoughts and

CHOOSE YOUR WORK

experiences are separate from you because you are something far greater. You grow to discover that emotions stemming from difficult experiences have a perverse allure, leading you to replay them over and over in your head. But when you write about the experience and let it go, you uncover its hidden value as you progress to the next stage of your growth.

The Hidden Gift

Reflecting on the challenging experience visualized in this chapter:

1. What is the strongest emotion that surfaces when I think about my challenging experience? (e.g., fear, gratitude, relief, frustration)
2. As I sit with this emotion, what emerges as truly important? What have I learned about myself from this experience, and how have I grown from it?
3. Based on what I have learned, what is a project that I would love to pursue?

Duration

Two minutes per question

Feel free to extend this reflection if you're finding it valuable. Writing about challenges can be emotional, so be gentle with yourself. Through this reflection, you're beginning the process of transforming your challenges into sources of strength and insight.

Like the *kintsugi* master carefully mending cracks with gold, you're finding beauty and clarity in your struggles. Let this new perspective guide your choice of work. Perhaps a past experience revealed a hidden strength or highlighted a problem you're now driven to solve. Connect the dots between past and present to envision a project that feels less like a job and more like a calling.

Since this activity is more emotional than others, many find that writing by hand is the best way to complete it.

This image shows a single page of white paper with horizontal ruling lines. The lines are evenly spaced and extend across the width of the page. There are no margins, text, or other markings on the paper.

-

7

Let the Work Choose You

How to tap into your intuition to reach the next level of growth.

The Secret to the Success of Steve Jobs, Oprah Winfrey, and Albert Einstein

Humanity has achieved some incredible things. We've designed airplanes and rockets and traveled to the Moon. We've built soaring skyscrapers, the Eiffel Tower, the Sistine Chapel, and created GPS technology to easily navigate from one place to another. We painted the Mona Lisa, composed Boléro, and created countless other incredible works of art and music. We split the atom, spliced the genome, and sequenced our DNA. We now have more computing power in our pocket than the system that sent the first rocket to the Moon.

Were these achievements accomplished by someone who worked for ten minutes, checked social media, did another fifteen minutes, watched a YouTube video, did another seven minutes, and then got a snack? Were these things achieved by someone who was constantly procrastinating? Is that how we sent a rocket to the Moon? No. How then were these feats accomplished?

CHOOSE YOUR WORK

Let's start with the iPhone. Steve Jobs is widely known as the co-founder of Apple. What's not as well known is the journey he took just before founding Apple. When Jobs was in his early twenties, he was unsure of his purpose and direction. He dropped out of Reed College to explore different paths. Jobs then traveled to India to study Zen Buddhism. During this time, he felt a profound sense of peace and clarity as he discovered the importance of intuition.

Based on that formative experience, Jobs founded Apple with Steve Wozniak and emphasized that intuition guided the design and features of the iPod, iPhone, and iPad. While Jobs was admired for his exceptional technological achievements, he did not attribute his success to his technical skills. He attributed it to listening to his intuition. It's no coincidence that Oprah Winfrey, Albert Einstein, Steven Spielberg, and Serena Williams all placed a high value on intuition.

To what degree do you use your intuition in your work? When you're dealing with tasks you don't enjoy, it's common to start and stop because your heart just isn't in it. We have all procrastinated out of laziness, but sometimes procrastination provides a clue that maybe this is not the work you're meant to do. Work *hindered by procrastination* becomes a battle of self-discipline as you push yourself to get it done. In contrast, work *guided by intuition* is a listening activity that pulls you into its warm embrace.

Observe the moments when work pulls you in. This book is called *Choose Your Work*, but actually, you want to listen for when the work is choosing you. This is particularly important because there are many ways to hack procrastination, such as using a countdown timer to focus on a single task and putting one song on repeat. These techniques work; we overcome procrastination and get the job done. But be careful what you wish for because you might just get it. You get the job done while you neglect the work that you are meant to do. Grinding through tasks may bring you praise from others, but it does not justify abandoning your true self. We are told to develop grit to be successful, but what about the dark side of grit?

The Dark Side of Grit

Writer and venture capitalist Paul Graham tells the story about his friend, a successful doctor who constantly complained about her job. When she was in high school, she impulsively decided to be a doctor. She let her high school self choose her adult life and, driven solely by ambition, persisted despite it being a dull and draining experience. This is the sunk cost fallacy in motion.

The sunk cost fallacy is a cognitive bias that we all experience, causing us to make irrational decisions. It occurs when we let past investments dictate future choices. We continue to spend time, money, or effort on a project that no longer serves us purely because we feel committed to our initial investment. We stay in a job we hate because we are about to get promoted. We don't change careers because we have spent so long establishing our skills in our current profession. We hate admitting our mistakes, so we engage in behavior that is counterproductive. This needs to stop.

The first step to overcoming the sunk cost fallacy is to realize you cannot change the past. You only have from today until the end of your life, so embrace the remaining time. Develop thoughtful quit criteria. These are the conditions that, if met, mean it is time for you to move on. For example, you may require a quiet, peaceful environment free from abusive language, along with challenging work that makes you think deeply for long, uninterrupted periods of time. Define conditions that are meaningful to you, with as many specifics as possible, and then give yourself at least a few months to assess whether these criteria are being met. Journal each day and summarize your thoughts each week. After a few months, it will become obvious what you need to do next.

I remember being halfway through my engineering degree, knowing that I would never become an engineer, but the sunk cost fallacy kept me captive for several more years. I clung to my engineering degree, telling myself I had invested too much time and effort to abandon it, even though my heart wasn't in it. Every time I thought about switching

CHOOSE YOUR WORK

paths, I felt an overwhelming sense of embarrassment. I didn't want to admit to friends and family that I had just wasted several years of my life. It was not until I left my corporate job that I realized clinging to the past was preventing me from choosing my work in the present. Letting go of that sunk cost was liberating, allowing me to appreciate each moment of the work that I was meant to do.

As a business owner, I also couldn't help recognizing the grip that the sunk cost fallacy had on my journey. The countless hours, the intense effort, and the emotional investment meant that it was all too easy to stay tethered to my business out of sheer inertia. I gradually realized that every business owner will leave their business one day. The question is not if, but when and why. Will it be at the peak of your health and enthusiasm, strategically planned for optimal sale value? Or will it be a reluctant retirement, driven by necessity rather than desire? Confronting the sunk cost fallacy forced me to define my own exit strategy. It challenged me to honestly assess whether my business was fulfilling my deepest aspirations or merely holding me hostage to past decisions.

Ultimately, I recognized that while I greatly enjoyed operating the business, writing brought me more joy. Having fallen prey to the sunk cost fallacy in the past, I was better equipped to identify its subtle influence. So, I decided to do whatever it took to hire a replacement.

Grit and determination can be useful. These qualities helped me get good grades and a highly sought-after corporate job. But the downside of grit and determination is that they are blind. Grit got me into a job that appeared impressive but felt completely meaningless. It took me some time to realize that untempered ambition is so narrowly focused that it lacks the space to listen to intuition. It coaxes us to plow forward, to surge ahead, to power through. But if you're on the wrong path, forward motion is just applying force to a dead end.

Why Intuition Must Come Before Grit

To see why intuition must guide grit, let's examine the diagram displayed below. Intuition is the fourth quadrant; it is what you don't know that you know.

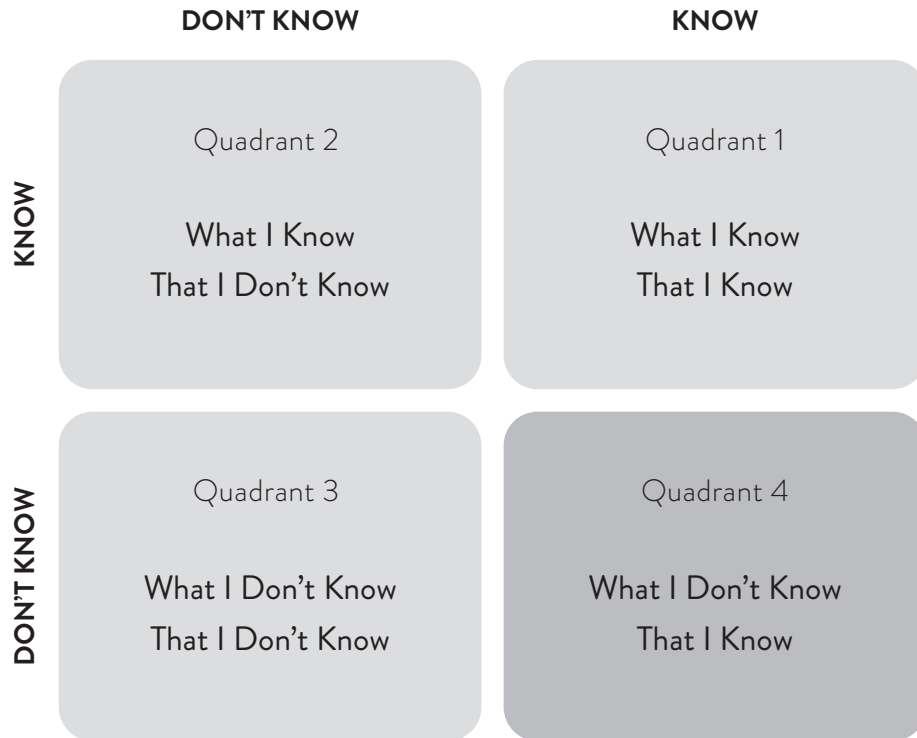


Figure 3: The Awareness Map

Quadrant One is what you know that you know. You know the capital city of the country you call home.

Quadrant Two is what you know that you don't know. You know that you don't know about astrobiology.

Quadrant Three is what you don't know that you don't know. These aren't just things you don't know. These are topics that you have no awareness of. For example, the Dunning–Kruger effect is a cognitive bias where people with low skill at a task overestimate their ability. Many are

unaware of this bias, acting with overconfidence to their detriment. The things you don't know that you don't know are your blind spots.

Quadrant Four is the most important quadrant for this book. It is what you don't know that you know. This may sound a bit odd. At first you may say, "Either I know it, or I don't know it!" But it's not that simple. Let's say that you experienced an emotional event and you decide to write about it. As you write, insights arrive that you were not able to access before you started writing. You refine your writing even further. At the end of it, you exclaim, "Huh! Interesting! I didn't realize that I knew this. I will have to put my reflections in writing more often."

Putting your reflections in writing is one way to activate your intuition because it reduces the unhelpful chatter in your head. How else can we tap into our intuition?

The Body Contains Wisdom That the Mind Cannot Comprehend

The work that you are meant to do is not an answer you get back from doing an online personality quiz. It's not an analytical process. It is not a task you can check off. The problem is that we have been schooled to be so logical that it's easy to lose touch with what feels right. Our culture does not encourage us to pause and reflect; it encourages us to get things done and move to the next project. These conditions make it nearly impossible to make any meaningful progress.

Your work is a mystery waiting to be discovered. Just as you are unique, so too is your work. To tap into the distinctiveness that you embody, you need to penetrate to the core of your true self. Start by becoming intensely aware of how you feel when you engage in your work. What sort of sensations are you experiencing in your body?

- Are you breathing slowly and steadily, or quickly and unevenly?
- Is your body feeling energized or lethargic?

- Is your heart feeling calm or is it racing?
- Is your mind clear or confused?
- Are you smiling or frowning?
- Is your stomach feeling calm or uneasy?
- Are your eyes focused or constantly wandering?
- Do you have an extra spring in your step as you approach the start of work? Or is there hesitation?

I remember a moment early in my career, sitting in a high-rise office building, staring out at the cityscape. It was a prestigious job with a respectable salary, everything I was told I should want. But as I sat there, I felt this gnawing sensation in my chest, like something was profoundly wrong. It was a feeling I couldn't shake, a sense that I was not where I was supposed to be. At the time, I didn't understand it, but looking back, I realize it was my true self desperately trying to speak to me, urging me to listen to my intuition to find a path that resonated with my heart.

It's essential to distinguish between intuition and anxiety, as they can sometimes feel similar. Anxiety often presents as repetitive, fearful thought patterns, a loud sense of impending doom, or physical reactions like racing thoughts, shallow breathing, physical tension, and even a sense of panic. It tends to be rooted in a fear of the unknown or past experiences.

In contrast, intuition is more of a calm and persistent inner knowing. It's a quieter, more grounded feeling from your true self that guides you in a particular direction. While anxiety seeks to keep you safe by avoiding perceived dangers, intuition guides you toward your true path, often despite the fear. Learning to recognize this distinction can help you trust your intuition and follow it, even when it seems challenging.

Listen to your intuition. It contains inner wisdom that transcends logic. Its message provides the ultimate clue to help you choose your work.

Where Does Intuition Begin?

Connecting with your intuition is much like dreaming. While you can't force yourself to have a peaceful dream, you can relax before you go to bed. Similarly, intuition can't be forced, but you can create the ideal conditions.

Interestingly, neuroscience research has shown that increasing your heart rate variability (HRV) can enhance your intuition by strengthening the connection between your heart and brain. Studies have shown that higher HRV is associated with clearer thinking and improved intuitive decision-making. The starting point to increasing your HRV is to exercise daily, get consistent high-quality sleep, and engage in a mindfulness practice like breathwork or meditation.

To tap into your intuition, you need to tap into the deeper part of consciousness beyond the mind. Intuition begins at the end of thought. To get to the point beyond thought, write down every thought in your head. Keep writing until you can think of nothing more.

Thoughts are loud. You want to empty your mind of its chatter. This is why it's so important to contextualize the challenges from the past (see Chapter 2) and to get in touch with your true self (see Chapter 5).

You want to amplify the soft signals of the body over any reaction. You will connect with your intuition in the silent space beyond stimulus and response.

At least once a week, go to a park, forest, or beach, immerse yourself in nature, and start walking. Put your phone and watch out of reach, walk at a leisurely pace, and take in the peaceful surroundings. This simple act shuts down the industrial mindset that has turned time into a commodity that is bought and sold. When you stop measuring time and start inhabiting it, the mind begins to settle. Your body will feel lighter, mental chatter will fade, and intuition will gradually reveal itself. Open yourself to the deepest part of your being. Open yourself to possibility.

As you contemplate *your work* — not what job you're going to get — listen for a gentle nudge about a journey that you need to embark on. Listen to the quiet voice that softly seeks to guide you. Frequently, things will surface that you have always known to be true but somehow ignored. In this serene state, fresh insights emerge, pointing toward the work that you are meant to do.

*It will begin as a faint murmur, barely noticeable, scarcely seen.
But then you notice subtle hints.
Seemingly random events will collide to steer you to your work.
The quiet hush evolves into a soft hum.
The more you listen, the clearer the signal.
It's no longer a whisper, but a feeling and a knowing.
The feeling deepens, gains momentum, and transforms into energy.
The energy flows through your body like a wave of deep meditation.
You see your true self with clarity you've never experienced before.
The clarity is so intensely bright that you are left with no option
but to do your work... because to abstain would be to willfully
desert your true self in the light of day.
And just as a mother would never abandon her child, your primal
instincts do not permit you to desert your true self.
In this state, you are fully focused.
Distractions are a thing of the past.
Your fixity of attention calmly arises from your fixity of intention.
You progress rapidly because the path feels deeply right.
Your work feels natural.
It flows.
Gone is the resistance suffered from doing the wrong work.*

As you listen to the quiet call of intuition, it becomes increasingly difficult to accept the conventional definitions of failure and success.

The Definition of Failure

We have been told that the difference between success and failure lies in achieving goals that are specific, measurable, achievable, relevant, and time-bound. Notice how this definition omits any consideration of whether your work feels intrinsically right. This paradigm is based on a finite game, a game played to win and which ends once the time frame has expired.

If you write a book specifically to sell a certain number of copies, you are playing a finite game. You plan the book, write the book, and promote the book with the hope of achieving your goal. If you sell the number of copies in the given time frame, you are successful. If you do not, you are labeled a failure. But the real failure is being so attached to a finite game that you never play an infinite game.

In contrast to a finite game, an infinite game goes on forever. The sole reason for engaging in an infinite game is the inherent value of playing the game. You engage in work simply because the work feels *right*, because you have listened to your intuition. You may, for example, dedicate your life to the art of writing, to sharing impactful messages through various media, and to continually improving your ability to express yourself. You celebrate your victories and seek to grow from your failures, but in doing so, you realize that neither your victories nor your failures can diminish the intense fulfillment you derive from your writing journey.

So what pursuit is worth doing for at least a decade simply because it captivates your imagination?

When you find work that resonates with you, don't ignore it. It may take time for the practical aspects of your work to come together. That's okay because you are playing an infinite game, not a finite one. Your ability to identify an infinite game is far more valuable than any minor victory in a finite game.

If you write a book and don't get the results you want, but you know in your heart of hearts that you were put on this planet to write books,

that's okay. The field of writing is deep. If you audition for a role in a theater production and don't get it, that's okay. There will be other roles. The journey is not over.

Do not let a finite game deceive you into defining success as achieving a specific outcome in a given amount of time. Real success is about being so engaged in an activity that time disappears. There is great peace in knowing that you are fully complete, so you do not need to play a finite game. Instead, you focus on an infinite game that is the greatest expression of your wholeness. The short term becomes less important because you are fully committed to making things work in the long term.

When you are committed to the long term, you let go of any thought about the outcome and simply focus on giving your best to each input. As you focus on the inputs, you develop a love of questions. These questions irrepressibly urge you to keep pushing toward the next level. Perhaps nothing is more fulfilling than this deep-seated bittersweet love.

Amid the chaos and the distractions, you know that there is no rush. You sit back, comforted by the awareness that while the path is steep, it is the right path, and so you have no choice but to follow the winding trail. As you focus on the infinite game, you achieve more than you can imagine. Unexpected magic awaits you at each turn. This magic is not just in the achievements, but in the joy of playing the game without worrying about the finish line. You attract others who are also playing an infinite game, and together, you positively reinforce each other's journey. Together, you build an infinite culture that leaves a lasting impact far beyond the confines of any finite game.

Let's tap into your intuition through the reflection activity.

The Intuitive Path

1. *What is one recurring practice (e.g., walking, journaling, breathwork) I will do this week to listen more deeply to my intuition? When is the best time to schedule it in my calendar?*
2. *What's one decision I'm currently facing where I could use intuition as a guide?*
3. *When I tap into the subtle signals my intuition is sending me, what is the infinite game that I am being led to play?*

Duration

Three minutes

Spend a few minutes in quiet reflection, tuning into your body's subtle signals. Then write for a few minutes about the infinite game that emerges, allowing yourself to dream big and embrace the long-term vision.

Sometimes you might need to go on several walks before the signal is clear. Revisit this monthly as you cultivate your intuition. Your inner voice becomes clearer with consistent practice and attention.

This image shows a single sheet of white paper with horizontal ruling lines. The lines are evenly spaced and run across the width of the page. There are no margins, text, or other markings on the paper.

-

-

Praise for *Choose Your Work*

Choose Your Work is both deeply personal and profoundly universal. It is insightful, provocative, and quietly unsettling. It seamlessly blends research and real-world anecdotes with practical, step-by-step guidance to help you identify what matters most. This is a book for anyone who has ever sensed there must be more — more meaning, more joy, more alignment between who they are and the work they do.

Genia Janover | Award-Winning Former Principal | Bialik College | Former Fellow | Australian College of Educators

Dan Dobos says the scary, quiet thing out loud: how we spend our working lives is a choice. *Choose Your Work* is both a wake-up call and a practical roadmap for anyone ready to make that choice.

Ben Stickland | Co-Founder & CEO | Instamove

This is the kind of book I will go back to regularly. Some self-help books you read once. Others bring value over and over throughout your life. This is the latter.

Teshia Harding

Choose Your Work distills a lifetime of insights and wisdom into a practical guide to help you clarify what matters most.

Jonar Nader | Former IBM Executive | Author of *How to Lose Friends & Infuriate Your Boss*

Chapter Two alone helped me more than therapy has.

Kayla Giles

Choose Your Work is a timely and deeply needed guide for anyone who senses there must be more to work than simply earning a living. In a volatile world that pushes people toward conformity, this book offers a practical and thought-provoking path back to what truly matters.

Mark Bowles | Dean, Tasmanian School of Business and Economics | University of Tasmania

In my work as a psychotherapist, I see how easy it is to lose sight of who you truly are. *Choose Your Work* offers a thoughtful and compelling path back to yourself.

Kirk Fisher | Psychotherapist & Zen Teacher

Honest, raw, and real. *Choose Your Work* was exactly what I needed.

Christy Oshima

Unlike other career change manuals, this is a guide for those searching for fulfilling work that is both optimistic and encouraging.

Helen Praetz | Emeritus Professor and Former Pro Vice-Chancellor | RMIT University

If you know someone graduating college, buy them this book. If a friend just turned 30, buy them this book. Most people stumble into careers that 'kinda work' and there they remain stuck. Don't be like most people. Buy this book.

James Tuckerman | Founder | Anthill Magazine

Contents

	The Key to Making This Book Work for You	xiii
	This is not a book to simply read.	
1	What If My Whole Life Has Been Wrong?	1
	Why do so many people experience a deep sense of regret at the end of their lives?	
	<i>Pause: The Three-Year Mirror</i>	
2	The Unexpected Gifts Hidden in Your Struggles	17
	How to extract insights from your greatest challenges so they become pathways for growth.	
	<i>Pause: The Hidden Gift</i>	
3	Don't Confuse Success with Suffering in Comfort	33
	Why your focus on comfort is ruining your life and obscuring the true metrics of success.	
	<i>Pause: The Comfort Trap</i>	
4	How Do You Pay the Bills and Still Choose Your Work?	49
	The one hour that changes everything.	
	<i>Pause: The Hour of Possibility</i>	
5	How to Think Independently in a World Obsessed with Conformity	63
	Why does conforming to the herd hamper your personal growth?	
	<i>Pause: The Hidden Voice</i>	
6	Rational Work Only Produces Rational Results	79
	The unexpected path to extraordinary achievement.	
	<i>Pause: The Rational Trap</i>	
7	Let the Work Choose You	91
	How to tap into your intuition to reach the next level of growth.	
	<i>Pause: The Intuitive Path</i>	
8	How to Overcome the Curse of Competence	105
	Why traditional education may undervalue your greatest strength and what to do about it.	
	<i>Pause: The Curse of Competence</i>	

9	You Don't Really Want to Lie on the Beach All Day	115
	What is more valuable than \$100 million in cold hard cash?	
	<i>Pause: The Cathedral</i>	
10	Next Steps to a Fulfilling Life	131
	How to capitalize on this pivotal moment.	
	<i>Pause: The One Project</i>	
	Appendices	
1	Action Plan	141
	A roadmap to convert your insights into action.	
2	How Well-Meaning Parents Unknowingly Steer Their Children Away from Fulfilling Work	145
	Understanding the subtle yet powerful influence parents have on career choices.	
3	What Next?	149
	Stay connected and inspired on your path to fulfilling work.	
4	Frequently Asked Questions	151
	Answers to the most common questions about choosing your work.	
5	The Ten Most Important Questions to Help You Choose Your Work	153
	Start with just one question each day.	
6	Financial Planning for Choosing Your Work	157
	Practical financial strategies to help you on your new path.	
7	Summary and Bonus Strategies	159
	A short guide to help you take action.	
	Notes	161
	Index	190

**Have you ever felt the unnerving sensation that,
despite appearing successful, something deep down isn't quite right?**

When you look back at your life, will you be satisfied?
Or will you have regrets?

The dark side of grit is chasing goals that don't matter,
while your deepest desires quietly fade away.

The way forward is to realize that the secret to a
fulfilling life is to choose your work.

**In this thought-provoking book, packed with inspiration,
practical strategies, and insightful stories, you will discover...**

What is more valuable than \$100 million in cold hard cash?

•

How to extract insights from your greatest challenges to realize your potential

•

Strategies to choose your work while still paying the bills

•

Why being good at something may lead you down the
wrong path and how to find the right one

•

Why focusing on comfort can ruin your life and
obscure the true metrics of success



**This book will help you discover your deepest truth, redefine what
success means to you, and begin a fulfilling new chapter in your journey.**

"Compelling and thought-provoking. It inspired immediate action in my life."

Beau Florenosos

"Inspirational, memorable and unlike any self-help book I've read before."

Jean Rose Dogillo

"Engaging, energising and deeply thought-provoking."

Liz Treat